“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Madhya-līlā

Chapter 10

The Return of Śrī Caitanya

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I worship that raincloud, Gaura, who by the nectar of His own sight brought back to life the crops of His devotees, withered by the drought of separation.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 Earlier, when Mahāprabhu had gone to the south, King Pratāparudra summoned Sārvabhauma.

4 Bowing to him, the king offered him a seat and then asked him for news of Mahāprabhu.

5 “I have heard that a great soul has come from Gauḍa and is staying in your house, and that He is supremely merciful.

6 Everyone says that He has shown you great mercy. Be kind enough to let me see Him.”

7 The Bhaṭṭācārya said, “All that you have heard is true. But it is not possible for you to see Him.

8 He is a renounced sannyāsī who lives in solitude; not even in a dream would He meet a king.

9 Still, I would have found some way to arrange for you to see Him; but just now He has gone to the south."

10 The king asked, "Why did He leave Jagannātha and go away?" The Bhaṭṭācārya replied, "That is a pastime of great souls.

11 To purify the holy places, He travels on pilgrimage, and on that pretext He delivers worldly people.

12 "Devotees such as you are themselves holy places, my lord. By the Lord who dwells within your hearts, you make even the holy places holy." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.13.10)

13 That is the unchanging nature of a Vaiṣṇava. But He is no jīva: He is the independent Lord Himself."

14 The king said, "Why did you let Him go? Why did you not fall at His feet and do all you could to keep Him here?"

15 The Bhaṭṭācārya said, "He is the Lord Himself, fully independent — Śrī Kṛṣṇa in person. He depends on no one.

16 Even so, I tried very hard to keep Him; but the Lord's will is His own, and I could not hold Him back."

17 The king said, "Bhaṭṭa, you are the crest-jewel of the learned. Since you call Him Kṛṣṇa, I accept it as the truth.

18 When He comes here again, let me see Him just once and make my eyes fruitful."

19 The Bhaṭṭācārya said, “He will come back soon. I would like a secluded place for Him to stay.

20 It should be near the Lord Jagannātha and also quiet. Please choose and give such a place.”

21 The king said, “Kāśī Miśra’s house is just such a place. It is near the Lord and very secluded.”

22 Having said this, the king waited eagerly, and the Bhaṭṭācārya went and told Kāśī Miśra.

23 Kāśī Miśra said, “I am most fortunate: Prabhupāda will stay in my house!”

24 In this way all the people of Puruṣottama were eager to meet the Lord.

25 When everyone’s longing had grown intense, Mahāprabhu came back quickly from the south.

26 Hearing of it, everyone rejoiced. They all came to Sārvabhauma and pleaded with him:

27 “Arrange for us all to see the Lord. By your grace may we reach His feet.”

28 The Bhaṭṭācārya said, “Tomorrow the Lord will go to Kāśī Miśra’s house; there I will bring you all to meet Him.”

29 The next day Mahāprabhu went with the Bhaṭṭācārya and joyfully saw Jagannātha.

30 There the servants of the Deity met Him and gave Him *mahā-prasāda*, and Mahāprabhu embraced them all.

31 After seeing the Lord, Mahāprabhu came out, and the Bhaṭṭācārya brought Him to Kāśī Miśra's house.

32 Kāśī Miśra came and fell at the Lord's feet, offering Him himself together with his house.

33 The Lord showed him His four-armed form, made him His own and embraced him.

34 Then Mahāprabhu sat down there, and the devotees headed by Nityānanda sat all around Him.

35 The Lord was pleased to see how the residence was arranged: it held everything He would need.

36 Sārvabhauma said, "Lord, this residence is fit for You. Please accept it — that is Kāśī Miśra's hope."

37 The Lord said, "This body belongs to all of you. Whatever you say, that I must do."

38 Then Sārvabhauma, seated at the Lord's right, began to introduce to Him all the residents of Puruṣottama:

39 "Lord, all these people live in Nīlācala. They have all been longing to meet You.

40 As thirsty *cātaka* birds cry out in distress, so have all of them. Please accept them all.

41 This is Janārdana, a servant of Jagannātha. During the *anavasara* he serves the Lord's divine body.

42 This is Kṛṣṇadāsa, who bears the golden staff, and this is Śikhi Māhiti, the scribe.

43 This is Pradyumna Miśra, the foremost of the Vaiṣṇavas; he is a great sevitor of Jagannātha, known by the name "Dāsa."

44 This is Murāri Māhiti, Śikhi Māhiti's brother. He has no refuge but Your feet.

45 Candaneśvara, Siṁheśvara, Murāri the brāhmaṇa and Viṣṇudāsa — they all meditate on Your feet.

46 This is the Praharāja Mahāpātra, a man of great wisdom; his name is Paramānanda Mahāpātra.

47 All these Vaiṣṇavas are the ornaments of this holy place. With one-pointed devotion they all think of Your feet."

48 Then they all fell flat on the ground like rods, and the Lord graciously embraced each of them.

49 Just then Bhavānanda Rāya arrived and, with his four sons, fell at Mahāprabhu's feet.

50 Sārvabhauma said, "This is Bhavānanda Rāya. His eldest son is Rāmānanda Rāya."

51 Then Mahāprabhu embraced him and spoke at length in praise of Rāmānanda:

52 “The glory of one whose son is a jewel like Rāmānanda cannot be described in this world.

53 You are Pāṇḍu himself, and your wife is Kuntī; your five wise sons are the five Pāṇḍavas.”

54 Rāya said, “I am a fallen, worldly śūdra, yet You touch me — this is the mark of the Lord.

55 Together with my house, my wealth, my servants and my five sons, I have surrendered myself at Your feet.

56 This Vāṇīnātha will stay at Your feet and carry out whatever You order, whenever You order it.

57 Regard me as Your own and do not hesitate with me: whatever You want, whenever You want it, give the order.”

58 The Lord said, “Why should I hesitate? You are no stranger. Birth after birth you and your family have been My servants.

59 Rāmānanda will come within five or seven days. In his company My joy will be complete.”

60 Saying this, the Lord embraced him, and his sons all placed the Lord’s feet on their heads.

61 Then Mahāprabhu sent him home, keeping Vāṇīnātha Paṭṭanāyaka with Him.

62 The Bhaṭṭācārya saw all the people off, and the Lord then called for Kālā Kṛṣṇadāsa.

63 The Lord said, “Bhaṭṭācārya, hear what this man did. He went with Me to the south.

64 There he left Me and went off to the Bhaṭṭathāris; I rescued him from them and brought him back.

65 Now that I have brought him here, I have dismissed him. Let him go wherever he likes; I am no longer responsible for him.”

66 Hearing this, Kṛṣṇadāsa began to weep, and Mahāprabhu went off to attend to His midday duties.

67 Then Nityānanda, Jagadānanda, Mukunda and Dāmodara took counsel among themselves:

68 “We need to send someone to Gauḍa to go and tell mother of the Lord’s return.

69 When they hear of the Lord’s return, all the devotees headed by Advaita and Śrīvāsa will come.

70 We will send this Kṛṣṇadāsa to Gauḍa.” Saying this, they reassured him and kept him with them.

71 The next day they put their request to the Lord: “Give us permission to send someone to Gauḍa.

72 Ever since they heard that You went south, mother Śacī and all the devotees headed by Advaita have been grieving.

73 Let someone go and tell them the good news.” The Lord said, “Do as you wish.”

74 So they sent that Kṛṣṇadāsa to Gauḍa, and gave him *mahā-prasāda* to give to all the Vaiṣṇavas.

75 Kālā Kṛṣṇadāsa came to Gauḍa and went to mother Śacī in Navadvīpa.

76 He gave her the *mahā-prasāda*, bowed to her and told her the news: the Lord had come back from the south.

77 Hearing it, mother Śacī rejoiced at heart, and so did Śrīvāsa and all the other devotees.

78 Everyone who heard it was overjoyed. Then Kṛṣṇadāsa went to the house of Advaita Ācārya.

79 He gave the Ācārya the *prasāda*, bowed to Him and told Him all the news of Mahāprabhu.

80 Hearing it, Ācārya Gosāñi was filled with joy. Absorbed in love, He danced and sang and roared again and again.

81–84 Haridāsa Ṭhākura was overjoyed, and so were Vāsudeva Datta, Murāri Gupta, Śivānanda Sena, Ācāryaratna, Vakreśvara Paṇḍita, Ācāryanidhi, Gadādhara Paṇḍita, Śrīrāma Paṇḍita, Dāmodara Paṇḍita, Śrīmān Paṇḍita, Vijaya, Śrīdhara, Rāghava Paṇḍita, Ācārya Nandana — how can I name all the other devotees?

85 Overjoyed at the news, they all went together to Śrī Advaita.

86 All of them bowed at the Ācārya's feet, and Ācārya Gosāñi embraced them all.

87 For two or three days the Ācārya held a great festival, and then He firmly resolved to go to Nīlācala.

88 They all gathered together in Navadvīpa and, taking mother Śacī's permission, set out for Nīlādri.

89 Hearing the news of the Lord, the residents of Kulīna-grāma — Satyarāja, Rāmānanda and all the rest — came and joined them.

90 Mukunda, Narahari and Raghunandana came from Khaṇḍa to the Ācārya to go to Nīlācala.

91 At that time Paramānanda Purī, coming from the south along the bank of the Gaṅgā, arrived in the town of Nadīyā.

92 He stayed happily in mother Śacī's house, and she respectfully gave him his meal.

93 There he heard of the Lord's return, and he wanted to go to Nīlācala at once.

94 Taking with him one of the Lord's devotees, a brāhmaṇa named Kamalākānta, he set out for Nīlācala.

95 He came quickly and met the Lord, and the Lord rejoiced to have him there.

96 Overwhelmed with love, the Lord bowed at his feet, and Paramānanda Purī, overwhelmed with love, embraced the Lord.

97 The Lord said, "I long to live in your company. Be merciful to Me and make Nīlādri your home."

98 Purī replied, "I too long to live in Your company. That is why I set out from Gauḍa and came to the city of Nīlācala.

99 When they heard that You had come back from the south, Śacī was overjoyed, and so were all the devotees.

100 They are all coming to see You, but seeing that they were delayed, I came on ahead in haste."

101 The Lord gave him a secluded room in Kāśī Miśra's house, and a servant to attend him.

102 The next day Svarūpa Dāmodara arrived — the Lord's most intimate companion, an ocean of *rasa*.

103 In his former *āśrama* his name was Puruṣottama Ācārya, and he lived in Navadvīpa at the Lord's feet.

104 When he saw the Lord accept *sannyāsa*, he became as if mad; he went to Vārāṇasī and took *sannyāsa* himself.

105 His guru, Caitanyānanda, ordered him, "Study Vedānta and teach it to everyone."

106 He was supremely renounced and supremely learned, and with body and mind he had taken shelter of Śrī Kṛṣṇa and His pastimes.

107 "I shall worship Kṛṣṇa free of every care" — for this very reason he accepted *sannyāsa* in his madness.

108 He accepted *sannyāsa* in the form of giving up his *śikhā* and sacred thread, but he was not given the *yogapaṭṭa*, and his name became "Svarūpa."

109 With his guru's leave he came to Nīlācala, and there, night and day, he was overwhelmed with the bliss of love for Kṛṣṇa.

110 He was the very limit of learning, yet he spoke with no one; he lived in solitude, and people did not know him.

111 He knew the truth of Kṛṣṇa's *rasa*, and his very body was love embodied; he was Mahāprabhu's second self.

112 If anyone brought the Lord a book, a verse or a song, the Lord would hear it only after Svarūpa had examined it.

113 Anything contrary to the conclusions of *bhakti*, or any *rasābhāsa* (a distorted *rasa*), brought the Lord's heart no delight when He heard it.

114 Therefore Svarūpa Gosāñi examined everything, and only if it was pure did he let the Lord hear it.

115 With the songs of Vidyāpati and Caṇḍīdāsa and the *Śrī Gīta-govinda* — these three — he delighted the Lord.

116 In music he was like a Gandharva, in scripture a Bṛhaspati; there was no one else so great-minded as Dāmodara.

117 He was most dear to Advaita and Nityānanda, and to Śrīvāsa and the other devotees he was as dear as life itself.

118 That Dāmodara came and fell prostrate before the Lord, and, clasping His feet, he began to recite a verse:

119 "O Śrī Caitanya, ocean of mercy! May Your mercy rise in all its fullness — the mercy that effortlessly shakes off the dust of distress and makes the heart pure, that unfolds a fragrant joy, that stills the quarrels over scripture, that bestows *rasa* and fills the heart with divine madness, that ever delights in devotion, that is full of rapture and is the very limit of sweetness." (Caitanya-candrodaya-nāṭaka, 8.14)

120 Mahāprabhu raised him up and embraced him, and both of them, overwhelmed with love, lost consciousness.

121 After a while, when they had both grown calm, Mahāprabhu began to speak to him:

122 “Today I saw in a dream that you would come. How good this is — as if a blind man had gained his two eyes!”

123 Svarūpa said, “My Lord, forgive my offence. I left You and went elsewhere — I have made a grave mistake.

124 I have not a trace of love for Your feet; sinner that I am, I left You and went off to another land.

125 I left You, but You did not leave me: You bound me by the neck with the rope of Your mercy and brought me back to Your feet.”

126 Then Svarūpa bowed at the feet of Nitāi, and Nityānanda Prabhu embraced him with love.

127 He met Jagadānanda, Mukunda, Śaṅkara and Sārvabhauma, greeting each as was fitting.

128 He bowed at the feet of Paramānanda Purī, and Purī Gosāñi embraced him with love.

129 Mahāprabhu gave him a secluded dwelling and a servant to bring him water and see to his other needs.

130 The next day Mahāprabhu was sitting with Sārvabhauma and other devotees, joyfully speaking of Kṛṣṇa.

131 At that moment Govinda arrived; bowing down, he humbly said:

132 “I am the servant of Īśvara Purī, and my name is Govinda. On Purī Gosāñi’s order I have come to You.

133 When he was attaining perfection, Gosāñi ordered me, ‘Go to Kṛṣṇa Caitanya and serve Him.’

134 Kāśīśvara will come after visiting all the holy places, but on my master’s order I have hurried to Your feet.”

135 The Lord said, “Purīśvara has always had a father’s affection for Me; out of mercy he has sent you to Me.”

136 Hearing this, Sārvabhauma asked the Lord, “Why did Purī Gosāñi keep a servant of *śūdra* birth?”

137 The Lord said, “Īśvara — the Lord, and so too Īśvara Purī — is supremely independent; the mercy of Īśvara is not subject to the rules of the Vedas.

138 The mercy of Īśvara takes no account of caste or family: Kṛṣṇa ate in the house of Vidura.

139 Śrī Kṛṣṇa’s mercy waits only for loving service; controlled by love, He acts free of all rules.

140 For Him whose very name brings supreme bliss to those who hear it, loving dealings give millions of times more joy than reverential formality.”

141 Saying this, the Lord embraced Govinda, and Govinda bowed at the Lord’s feet.

142 The Lord said, “Bhaṭṭācārya, consider this: My guru’s servant is worthy of My respect.

143 It is not proper for Me to have him serve Me, yet My guru has ordered it. What am I to do?”

144 The Bhaṭṭa said, “The guru’s order is powerful, and one does not transgress it — scripture is the proof:

145 “Having heard that Bhārgava (Paraśurāma), on his father’s order, struck down his own mother as though she were an enemy, he (Lakṣmaṇa) accepted that command of his elder brother. The orders of one’s elders are not to be questioned.” (Raghu-vaṁśa, 14.46)

146 “The order of my guru, that great soul, must be carried out by me without deliberation; in this lies your good, and especially mine.” (Rāmāyaṇa, Ayodhyā-kāṇḍa, 22.9)

147 Then Mahāprabhu accepted him and gave him the right to serve His own sacred person.

148 Everyone honoured Govinda as the Lord’s dear servant, and Govinda looked after all the Vaiṣṇavas.

149 The two Haridāsas, the junior and the senior, both *kīrtana* singers, and Rāmāi and Nandāi stayed with Govinda.

150 Together with Govinda they served the Lord. The limit of Govinda’s good fortune cannot be described.

151 The next day Mukunda Datta came to the Lord and said, “Brahmānanda Bhāratī has come to see You.

152 If You permit, shall I bring him here?" The Lord said, "He is My guru; I shall go to him Myself."

153 Saying this, Mahāprabhu set out with the devotees and came before Brahmānanda Bhāratī.

154 Brahmānanda was wearing a deerskin, and when the Lord saw it He was pained at heart.

155 Though He saw him, He pretended not to, and asked Mukunda, "Where is Bhāratī Gosāñi?"

156 Mukunda said, "Here he is, right before You." The Lord said, "That is not he. You are mistaken.

157 You are taking someone else for him — you do not know. Why would Bhāratī Gosāñi wear a hide?"

158 Hearing this, Brahmānanda reflected in his heart: "He does not like this skin garment of mine.

159 He is right: I wear this skin only out of pride. Wearing a skin will not carry me across *saṁsāra*.

160 From today I shall not wear this skin." Knowing his heart, the Lord had a *sannyāsī*'s outer cloth brought for him.

161 When Brahmānanda had cast off the skin and put on cloth, the Lord came and bowed at his feet.

162 Bhāratī said, "Your conduct is meant to teach people. I am afraid in my heart that You will not bow to me again.

163 Now there are two Brahmans here, the moving and the unmoving: Jagannātha is the unmoving Brahman, and You are the moving Brahman.

164 You are golden in colour and He is dark; these two Brahmans are delivering the whole world."

165 The Lord said, "I tell you the truth: with your arrival two Brahmans have become manifest in Śrī Puruṣottama.

166 You, whose name is Brahmānanda, are the golden Brahman, the moving one, while dark Jagannātha sits there unmoving."

167 Bhāratī said, "Sārvabhauma, be the arbiter and consider carefully this argument between Him and me.

168 I understand the *jīva* and Brahman as the pervaded (*vyāpya*) and the pervader (*vyāpaka*): the *jīva* is pervaded and Brahman is the pervader — so scripture explains.

169 By removing my skin He has purified me, and the reason is just this relation between us two — of the pervaded and the pervader.

170 "He is of golden colour, His limbs are like gold, His form is beautiful, and He wears armlets of sandal. He has taken sannyāsa, He is self-restrained and tranquil, and His highest refuge is steadfastness and peace." (Mahābhārata, Dāna-dharma, 149; Viṣṇu-sahasra-nāma, 92 and 75)

171 He is the very abode of all these names: the sandal-anointed cords of *prasāda* on His two arms are His armlets."

172 Bhaṭṭācārya said, "Bhāratī, I see that the victory is yours." The Lord said, "Whatever you say is true.

173 In a dispute between guru and disciple, the disciple's defeat is certain." Bhāratī said, "That is not so; there is another reason.

174 It is Your nature to be defeated by Your devotees. Now hear one thing more — about Your own power.

175 All my life I meditated on the formless, but on seeing You, Kṛṣṇa has become manifest to me.

176 The name of Kṛṣṇa springs to my lips, and Kṛṣṇa fills my mind and eyes. Seeing You as that very form, my heart is filled with longing.

177 The very change that Bilvamaṅgala underwent has come over me on seeing Him:

178 "Though we were worshipped by those who travel the path of nondualism and were initiated onto the throne of self-contained bliss, we have been forcibly made maidservants by a certain cunning youth, the lover of the gopīs."

179 The Lord said, "You have deep love for Kṛṣṇa; wherever your eyes fall, Kṛṣṇa manifests to you."

180 Bhaṭṭācārya said, "Your words are true — if Kṛṣṇa first grants His direct sight.

181 Without love there is never any direct vision of Him; it is by the mercy of this One that this one has had His sight."

182 The Lord said, "Viṣṇu! Viṣṇu! What are you saying, Sārvabhauma? Such excessive praise is a mark of censure."

183 Saying this, the Lord brought Bhāratī to His own residence, and Bhāratī Gosāñi stayed near the Lord.

184 Rāmabhadrācārya and Bhagavān Ācārya also stayed at the Lord's feet, setting aside all other affairs.

185 The next day Kāśīśvara Gosāñi came, and the Lord received him with honour and kept him with Himself.

186 He would take the Lord for the *darśana* of Jagannātha, walking ahead and keeping back the crowds.

187 As all rivers and streams flow into the ocean, so Mahāprabhu's devotees, wherever they were,

188 all came and met at the Lord's holy feet, and the Lord mercifully kept them all with Him.

189 Thus I have described the Lord's meeting with the Vaiṣṇavas. Whoever hears this attains the feet of Caitanya.

190 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.